International Relations

Sanctions

Sanctions: Economic or political penalties imposed by one or more countries (or international bodies) on a target state, group, or individual to coerce a change in behaviour. Sanctions can include trade embargoes, asset freezes, travel bans, arms embargoes, and restrictions on financial transactions.

Arguments Against Sanctions

1. **Sanctions are unlikely to inflict sufficient harm on targeted countries.**
   - Empirically, sanctions have often failed—e.g. Saddam Hussein in Iraq, the Kim regime in North Korea.
   - Over time, sanctions lose their bite as countries develop *sanction resilience*: trading with other countries, depositing funds into foreign bank accounts, etc.
   - Countries often know in advance that they will face international condemnation, so they extensively *sanction-proof* their economies beforehand.
   - Nations have a game-theoretic incentive to *undercut* sanctions regimes and trade with sanctioned nations anyway; the complexity of international trade makes enforcement difficult.
   - The *types* of sanctions foreign nations tend to impose are watered-down, because the imposing governments are also harmed by sanctions and thus have incentives to minimise their own costs.
2. **Even if sanctions are effective, countries are unlikely to capitulate.**
   - Sanctions are ideologically localised (imposed for specific wrongdoings), but countries fear that giving in will set a precedent, inviting further sanctions in the future.
   - Sanctions are often imposed by the West; strong-man authoritarian leaders—especially in post-colonial states—refuse to appear weak or subservient to foreign powers.
   - *Sanction fatigue* sets in among the imposing nations; targeted countries believe they can simply outlast the sanctions.
   - Sanctioned countries know that democratic governments oscillate between parties, so they credibly believe sanctions may be relaxed by a future political regime anyway.
3. **Even if sanctions cause damage, that damage actively worsens the situation on the ground.**
   - Harmful actors use sanctions as a political weapon, framing them as extensions of *Western neo-colonialism*; this increases domestic buy-in and portrays the regime as a bulwark against the West. Governments can also frame protesters as *colluding with the West*.
   - Sanctions provide a convenient excuse for governments to avoid accountability—they offload blame for economic mismanagement onto the West.
   - Sanctioned countries turn to *worse, more harmful actors*: e.g. buying weapons from Russian cartels on the black market, or illegal armed groups turning to drug trafficking or blood-diamond trading.
   - Sanctions disproportionately harm *vulnerable communities*: wealthy elites are highly insulated, while the poor are hit hardest.
   - The emergence of a strong middle class is a crucial precondition for internal liberalisation movements; sanctions stunt economic development and make this far less likely.

- Sanctions often worsen political repression by vindicating despotic regimes' fears of foreign hostility, amplifying the incentive to further consolidate power, conduct missile tests, and pursue aggressive militarisation.

4. **Sanctions have broader third-party harms.**
   - Sanctions are often imposed where humanitarian crises are widespread, but they problematise inflows of humanitarian aid (food, medicine, clean water) because bureaucratic and regulatory customs measures slow delivery, and the legal ambiguity makes aid groups worry about financial repercussions.
   - Imposing nations lose out on the benefits of trade; domestic opponents of sanctions may become apologists for the abuses of the sanctioned nation.
   - Targets of sanctions often impose *retaliatory sanctions* in the inverse direction. Neighbouring countries that trade extensively with the sanctioned state also suffer economic hits.

Examples of Failed Sanctions

- **Cuba**—Since 1962, the US has unilaterally maintained a near-total embargo on Cuba. Despite over six decades, Cuba's single-party authoritarian government persists, minimal reform has been implemented, and an estimated $114B in economic development has been stunted. Poverty is widespread, and aid organisations fear hefty US fines for providing assistance.
- **North Korea**—Since 2006, multilateral sanctions (EU, UNSC) have included full-scale global embargoes on North Korean weapons, luxury goods, remittances, and minerals. These have largely failed because UN-imposed sanctions were watered down (to avoid Russian or Chinese vetoes) and because North Korea sells and imports goods on the black market via smuggling (particularly through its close economic ties to China). North Korea has *accelerated* its missile development programme since the first wave of sanctions.
- **Haiti**—In 1990, Jean-Bertrand Aristide was democratically elected in a landslide. In 1991, the military staged a coup. The Organisation of American States imposed a comprehensive trade embargo, followed by the UN in 1993. Sanctions failed to invoke regime change but had devastating civilian effects: nearly 14,000 people immediately put out of work, and the fuel embargo caused mass power outages, crippling the medical system and leading to thousands of deaths.
- **Yugoslavia**—During the early Yugoslav Wars in the 1990s, the European Economic Community (precursor to the EU) and the UN aggressively sanctioned Serbia for war crimes in Croatia and Bosnia. These had little effect on the military (cooperation only began after NATO militarily intervened years later), but led to mass shortages of food and medicine among civilians.
- **Iraq**—Following Saddam Hussein's 1990 invasion of Kuwait, UNSC Resolution 661 banned international trade with and investment into Iraq. Sanctions remained largely in place until the 2003 US invasion. They failed to oust Hussein but doubled the child mortality rate, crippled the healthcare system, and induced a famine so severe that nearly one-third of Iraq's population was categorised as malnourished. Two high-level UN officials resigned in protest; one said he did not "want to administer a program that satisfies the definition of genocide."
- **Rhodesia**—In the 1960s, Rhodesia declared independence during a wave of decolonisation. The UNSC responded with sanctions that damaged the economy but failed to intimidate the regime; instead, they contributed to a fifteen-year civil war claiming tens of thousands of lives.
- **Angola**—Between 1975 and 2002, UNITA fought in the Angolan Civil War. By 1998,

UN sanctions were imposed; UNITA responded by increasing blood-diamond production, and profits from the diamond trade actually *increased*, as did violence.

Arguments For Sanctions

1. **Sanctions are likely to rein in harmful behaviour.**
   - Sanctions generate *leverage*—a bargaining chip to force countries to the negotiating table. Even if sanctions do not work directly, countries can threaten to ratchet them up; when the threat is credible, concessions can be extracted.
   - Sanctions can be *targeted* against specific elites (e.g. freezing financial assets of military generals, imposing travel restrictions on oligarchs), minimising collateral damage while pressuring powerful individuals to implement reforms.
   - Sanctions can target *specific industries* tied to the military or government apparatus (e.g. the Tatmadaw in Myanmar is heavily reliant on ruby exports), creating a direct economic incentive to capitulate.
   - To the extent sanctions affect the general population, they amplify incentives to reform: governments face credible fear of domestic backlash, and propaganda cannot convince someone they are not poor or hungry.
   - Sanctions harm private-sector companies by reducing revenues; even if companies evade sanctions, the costs of evasion (smuggling, etc.) cut into profits and incentivise companies to use their political influence to pressure governments into reform.
   - Sanctions accelerate *internal fracturing* within government institutions (e.g. the military): even a few disenchanted elites can create a self-amplifying cycle of opposition.
2. **Even if sanctions do not work directly, they are preferable to the alternatives.**
   - **Alternative 1: More aggressive action (invasion).** The likelihood of collateral damage is far higher and deadlier in active military operations than under economic sanctions.
   - **Alternative 2: Less aggressive action (mere condemnation).** This signals that the international community is aware of abuses but unwilling to act meaningfully, *emboldening* future abuse by weakening deterrence.
   - Sanctions *invigorate protest movements* that explicitly advocate for sanctions; delivering on those promises legitimises and energises such movements.
   - The controversiality of sanctions generates media coverage of the underlying crisis and increases political capital for further corrective measures (technical support to rebels, humanitarian aid, etc.).

Examples of Successful Sanctions

- **Iran**—Decades of Western sanctions by the UNSC, US, and EU—originally for funding militant groups, later for its illegal nuclear weapons programme—tightly limited Iranian oil and gas exports and caused the rial to plummet. Sanctions partly contributed to the election of Hassan Rouhani, a moderate who promised cooperation with the West, and served as the primary bargaining chip to secure the JCPOA, restricting uranium enrichment and granting IAEA monitoring jurisdiction.
- **Malawi**—In 1991, when Malawi's one-party authoritarian government opened fire on student-led pro-democracy protests, the US and Western nations blocked foreign aid. Economic output dropped nearly 7%, and the government subsequently announced a new constitution paving the way for multi-party elections and universal suffrage.
- **South Africa**—In the lead-up to 1994, a grassroots movement pushed for divestment from apartheid South Africa. Combined with post-Cold War Western government sanctions,

this led to considerable capital flight, ultimately pressuring the government to negotiate with the ANC.

- **Rwanda**—In 2013, the US and EU allies imposed financial and military sanctions against Rwanda for its extensive funding of violent rebel groups (e.g. M23) in the DRC. Rwanda subsequently ceased almost all such support.
- **Guatemala**—In 1993, President Jorge Serrano Elías attempted an *autogolpe* (self-coup): suspending the Constitution, dissolving Congress, and disbanding the Supreme Court. The Organisation of American States threatened a near-total embargo; within two weeks, Serrano fled and resigned, paving the way for a human rights advocate to succeed him.

Targeted Killings (Assassinations)

Arguments Against Assassination

- Killed leaders become *martyrs*: criminals venerate their image, and organisations spin the killing to increase recruitment.
- Organisations become *fragmented* into many cells. Without a unifying leader, groups engage in turf wars and compete for financing/membership by proving they are more violent or radical than rivals.
- In the process of splintering, new leaders lack the cult-of-personality of predecessors, giving them the incentive to "prove themselves" by being *extra violent*.
- It is far harder to *negotiate* with many fragmented terrorist cells than with a single leader willing to make concessions; it is also harder to negotiate when organisations deliberately conceal their internal leadership hierarchy.
- Legally, targeted assassinations may violate international law as *extrajudicial killings*.

Arguments For Assassination

- Governments use assassination as a "tool in the toolbox"; military generals—who have incentives to see conflicts end—can ensure decapitation is used selectively and strategically.
- Many criminal enterprises are led by *uniquely charismatic, talented, or skilled* individuals; killing even a few high-level officials can turn the tide. It shatters their façade as "all-powerful" and makes broad, ideologically diverse organisations harder to keep united. Smaller groups cannot access economies of scale and are easier to stop.
- Killing high-level leaders can *scare* leadership into negotiation (they face credible fear of being assassinated) and encourage lower-level criminals (drug peddlers, gang henchmen) to defect.
- The likely alternatives—outright intervention or indiscriminate drone strikes—are far more likely to endanger civilian lives.

Examples of Assassinations

War on Terror

- **Abu Musab al-Zarqawi**—Jordanian jihadist who relocated to Iraq and played a pivotal role in fomenting sectarian tensions leading to the Iraqi Civil War; assassinated by a US targeted killing in 2006.
- **Osama bin Laden**—Founder and leader of al-Qaeda; killed in 2011 in Operation Neptune Spear by SEAL Team 6 at his compound in Pakistan.
- **Ahmed Abdi Godane**—Emir (leader) of Somalia-based Al-Shabaab; killed by a US drone strike in 2014.

- **Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi**—Self-proclaimed leader of ISIS; in 2019, a US military operation targeted him, but he committed suicide before forces could kill him.
- **Qasem Soleimani**—Commander of a clandestine branch of Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps; assassinated by US airstrikes in early 2020. Iran responded with retaliatory strikes against American military bases.
- **US drone-strike criticism:** According to contemporary estimates, around nine children are killed for every adult the US attempts to assassinate. Only ∼8% of victims of US targeted killing campaigns are high-level organisers/leaders; the vast majority are foot soldiers.
- **Historical US precedent:** The first major US targeted killing came during WWII (Isoroku Yamamoto, organiser of Pearl Harbor). The US adopted a relative opposition to targeted killings between the late 1970s and 2001, although the US subcontracted death squads in Latin America to carry out targeted executions.

IDF "Focused Foiling"

- Israel's Mossad has carried out dozens of targeted strikes against Hezbollah and Hamas leaders. In 2012, Israel killed Ahmed Jabari, second-in-command of Hamas' militant wing. In 2004, Israel killed Ahmed Yassin and Abdel Aziz al-Rantisi, the two co-founders of Hamas.
- Mossad has been credibly linked to the assassination of at least four Iranian nuclear scientists.

Authoritarian Uses of Targeted Killings

- **North Korea:** Openly poisoned exiled reformist Kim Jong-nam (brother of Kim Jong-un and reported CIA asset) with a deadly nerve agent in a Malaysian airport in 2017.
- **Russia under Putin:** Extensive use of state-sponsored assassinations:
  - 2006: FSB poisoned Alexander Litvinenko, openly critical of Putin's "mafia state."
  - 2006: Killed Anna Politkovskaya, journalist and human rights activist who publicised abuses of the Putin regime.
  - 2015: Killed Boris Nemtsov, who published extensive evidence of Putin's corrupt authoritarianism.
  - 2020: Poisoned Alexei Navalny, famous Putin critic.
  - Since the outbreak of the Ukraine war, seven Russian oligarchs have been found dead under mysterious circumstances.

Military Invasions

Arguments For Invading

- Invasions are often the *only way* to accomplish change: sanctions frequently fail (evasion, sanction-proofing); diplomacy is a non-starter for governments that cannot afford to look weak. Invasion may be the best—and possibly only—solution for major, protracted crises.
- **Invasions are likely to work:**
  - Invading countries face intense domestic scrutiny; it is political suicide for politicians to greenlight a failed invasion.
  - Superior Western military technology and technical expertise can outmanoeuvre opposition forces.

  - *Shock-and-awe* tactics demoralise foot soldiers and scare military leaders into defecting, especially when coupled with promises of post-conflict amnesty.
  - Invasions accelerate internal fracturing within the highest levels of military leadership.
  - Neighbouring countries have incentives to bring about a speedy end to violence because prolonged conflict raises the risk of a refugee crisis.
- **The worst harms are unlikely to manifest:** Increasingly accurate military technology allows precise targeting, minimising collateral damage. Mass media scrutiny of battlefields creates preemptive incentives for militaries to avoid the worst excesses of abuse.

Arguments Against Invading

- **Alternatives exist:** Sanctions can target elites or supply chains; aid can ensure food and medicine reach civilians; organic revolutionary efforts can pressure governments to reform without foreign involvement.
- **Invasions are unlikely to work:**
  - Foreign interventions—especially Western-backed ones—often *galvanise* increased domestic support for abusive regimes.
  - The defending military has better knowledge of local terrain.
  - Foreign support for invasions is often low; as the *body-bag effect* kicks in, heavy political pressure to withdraw creates a power vacuum and further destabilises the region.
  - Civilian opposition to foreign invasions (propaganda, fear of foreign powers, genuine loyalty to the incumbent regime) means (1) it is difficult to distinguish combatants from civilians, and (2) massive resistance comes from civilians as well as soldiers.
  - Many of the most abusive countries are relatively underdeveloped, with heavily forested terrain that makes heavy artillery or aerial forces difficult; conventional infantry must be deployed, which tends to be quite bloody.
  - Even if the initial invasion succeeds, government loyalists can wage protracted, low-intensity guerrilla-style insurgencies (e.g. forested Myanmar, mountainous Afghanistan).
- Invasions kill huge numbers of people—many civilians caught in crossfire or killed as collateral damage. Civilians are often used as *human shields* by abusive regimes (e.g. Hamas in Gaza).
- **Post-conflict governance** is difficult: the resulting power vacuum is often seized by radicals, and elite infighting for power often results in the most extreme leader rising to the top.

Contemporary Examples of Invasions

- **Afghanistan (2001)**—The US and NATO allies intervened to drive out the Taliban (accused of harbouring al-Qaeda after 9/11). The US established an interim government; the Taliban waged a low-intensity insurgency for nearly two decades until the Biden-era US withdrawal led to the Taliban recapturing Kabul.
- **Iraq (2003)**—The US and Western/NATO allies intervened, officially due to (inaccurate and manufactured) fears of WMDs, and rhetorically to eliminate Saddam Hussein and liberate the Iraqi people. A brutal "Shock and Awe" bombing campaign rapidly drove Hussein from power. The Coalition Provisional Authority struggled to restore peace; nearly $8B in development aid was left unaccounted for, and $1.6B was found in cash in a basement in Lebanon. The power vacuum was compounded by the Shia-leaning Mahdi Army and Sunni-leaning al-Qaeda. By 2006, Iraq was plunged into violence fuelled by the

Sunni–Shia divide and the anti-US insurgency. The US completed withdrawal by 2011; regional instability contributed to the rise of IS.

- **Gambia (2017)**—President Yahya Jammeh refused to step down after losing the 2016 election. ECOWAS launched "Operation Restore Democracy," deploying ∼4,000 troops. Within two days, Jammeh fled.
- **Haiti (1994)**—After sanctions failed to oust the military junta that overthrew a democratic government in 1991, the US deployed 25,000 soldiers. The invasion successfully forced de facto dictator Raoul Cédras to capitulate with minimal casualties.
- Other examples: Israel (Gaza), Kosovo (NATO), Russia (Crimea/Ukraine).

Post-Invasion Occupations

Examples of Occupying Forces

- **Russian occupation of South Ossetia**—Located in Georgia in the South Caucasus, South Ossetia is a self-declared secessionist state under de facto Russian occupation since the 2008 Russo-Georgian War. It depends extensively on Russia for military, financial, and technical support.
- **American occupation of Iraq/Afghanistan**—Following the US-led invasions of Afghanistan (2001) and Iraq (2003), the US established transitional regimes. Both faced protracted ethno-political insurgencies. Afghanistan subsequently fell to the Taliban after US withdrawal; Iraq required US support to counter the territorial advances of IS.
- **Armenian occupation of Nagorno-Karabakh**—Located in the South Caucasus, officially within Azerbaijan (∼92% Azerbaijani), but with a majority ethnically Armenian population. In 1994, the First Nagorno-Karabakh War saw the region fall under de facto Armenian occupation. In 2020, another war broke out; a Russia-mediated peace deal resulted in Armenian withdrawal from much Azerbaijani territory, though Nagorno-Karabakh remained de facto autonomous despite lacking international recognition.

Proxy Conflicts

Military Aid

- **Plan Colombia (2000–2015)**—The US provided over $10B; most funds equipped counternarcotics forces and financed fumigation (toxic herbicides to eradicate coca). *Criticisms:* funded groups had ties to right-wing paramilitary death squads; the law-enforcement-driven approach was less effective than treatment-driven approaches; destruction of farmland led to *Boliviana negra* (glyphosate-resistant coca), environmental runoff harm, and the "balloon effect" (coca production shifting elsewhere). *Proponents:* between 2000 and 2015, Colombia's homicide rate fell 50%, kidnappings/terrorist attacks decreased 90%, and Colombian exports to the US quadrupled. The US spends an estimated $51B/year on the War on Drugs, with a lifetime price tag over $1T.
- **Israel**—The US pledged $38B in military aid (2019–2028), provides ∼$3B annually, and has given ∼$146B total since 1948. Israel has purchased dozens of F-35 fighters and constructed the Iron Dome missile defence system through US aid. During the 2014 Israel–Gaza Conflict, the US temporarily halted aid; Israel subsequently increased domestic military investment. Both sides increasingly question continued aid: Israel recognises that dependence gives the US leverage; the US recognises Israel's reduced need compared to the 20th century.
- **Egypt**—Since 1978, the US has provided ∼$50B in military aid; Egypt receives ∼20% of the US Foreign Military Financing budget. Criticisms include financing Egyptian scorched-earth tactics in Sinai against civilians, subsidising extrajudicial killings of po-

litical dissidents, and wasteful spending (e.g. Abrams tanks used almost exclusively for display in military parades).

- **Chinese military aid**—China gives relatively little: $560M (2013–2018), compared to $38B from the US in the same period. China has provided extensive aid to the African Union (∼$100M), Cambodia (∼$115M), and pre-Taliban Afghanistan (∼$78M).

Major Ongoing Proxy Conflicts

- **Syrian Civil War**—Russia and Iran provide extensive backing to the Assad regime in Damascus; the US and Saudi Arabia have, to varying extents, supported anti-Assad rebel groups and Kurdish militias.
- **Iran–Saudi Proxy Conflicts**—Saudi Arabia (majority Sunni, Wahhabi government) and Iran (majority Shia) wage proxy conflicts to expand regional influence in the Middle East, particularly in the Persian Gulf. This includes the war in Yemen and military tensions in the Gulf.
- **Russo-Ukraine War**—Extensive Western military support/aid to Zelenskyy's Ukraine (foreign weapons, munitions, missiles, intelligence reports) makes the war a de facto proxy conflict between Russia and the West, reminiscent of the Cold War.

Nuclear Weapons

- **Nine nuclear states:** China, France, India, Israel, North Korea, Pakistan, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States. The US has the largest stockpile; Russia and the US together hold ∼90% of the world's nuclear weapons.
- Most countries fall under the *nuclear umbrella* of at least one nuclear power—a de facto guarantee to use nuclear weapons in their defence.

Risks of Nuclear Weapons

- Nuclear weapons have the literal capacity to *wipe out existence*; Cold War investment produced weapons far surpassing Hiroshima/Nagasaki.
- Risk of use by *rogue actors*: dictatorships without clear succession (e.g. North Korea), terrorists without defined territorial boundaries (e.g. ISIS-K), and irrational actors.
- Accelerating proliferation raises the odds of *accidental nuclear strikes*—not just Cuban-Missile-Crisis scenarios, but dozens of near-misses historically.
- Nuclear weapons *embolden rogue actors* and give bad actors disproportionate leverage—e.g. North Korea gets away with mass human rights abuses because countries fear nuclear retaliation; Iran extracted significant concessions via the JCPOA by leveraging its programme.

Silver Linings of Nuclear Weapons

- Nuclear weapons are very unlikely to actually be used: extensive international oversight, mutual assured destruction (MAD), and built-in military checks and balances.
- Nuclear weapons create *deterrence via MAD*: India–China conflict has been confined to border skirmishes; India–Pakistan tensions have remained relatively non-violent; the Cold War stayed cold. *Counter-arguments:* (1) nuclear weapons only deter other nuclear weapons, and (2) MAD only holds if targeted nations have retaliatory capacities—hypersonic nuclear weapons could theoretically eliminate the ability to retaliate.
- The natural alternatives (chemical/biological weapons) are similarly destructive but harder to contain, harder to monitor, and more likely to fall into terrorist hands.

- Nuclear weapons programmes require investment in scientific research, which often creates educational systems and contributes to the rise of a burgeoning middle class.

Israel and Palestine

Pre-Haskalah History and Rise of Zionism

- Throughout its history, dating back thousands of years, Israel (or the territory historically known as Palestine) has been ruled by a variety of peoples, kingdoms, and empires—e.g. the Roman Republic and the Ottoman Empire. Israel has nearly always been a religiously diverse area, with Christians, Muslims, and Jews. Holy sites in Jerusalem attracted large numbers of foreigners.
- The late 18th century was marked by the **Haskalah:** ("Jewish Enlightenment"), which saw the rise of secular Jewish rationalism and philosophical thought.
- Towards the end of the 19th century, anti-Semitism intensified in central and eastern Europe. Theodor Herzl, an Austro-Hungarian Jewish political theorist, published *Der Judenstaat* ("The State of the Jews") in 1896, advocating for a Jewish homeland in Palestine. Herzl's advocacy became known as **Zionism:** and formed the foundation of Jewish nationalism.
- Most early Zionists were *secular Zionists*: they envisioned a state *for* Jewish people, rather than a Jewish state. A central ideology within many conceptions of Zionism is the "Negation of the Diaspora," positing that Jews will always face extreme persecution outside a Jewish homeland, thus amplifying the importance of creating a nation-state.
- By the turn of the 20th century, the Ottoman Empire ruled Palestine: ∼87% Muslim, ∼10% Christian, ∼3% Jewish. In Jerusalem, all three groups were represented at roughly equal levels.
- Under Ottoman rule, life in Palestine was predominantly peaceful: different ethnic and religious groups coexisted, and conflict was relatively rare.

World War I and British Involvement

- The Ottoman Empire was internally in shambles by 1914: the Balkan Wars (1913) saw the secession of European provinces; the Raid on the Sublime Porte (a coup d'état) ushered in unstable single-party rule.
- After WWI broke out, the Ottomans sided with the Central Powers. Britain sought to undermine Ottoman rule in the Middle East by secretly communicating with the Sharif of Mecca, promising to recognise an independent, unified Arab state from Syria to Yemen in exchange for an uprising against the Ottomans.
- Hussein bin Ali, the Sharif, led the **Great Arab Revolt**, backed by Britain, expelling the Ottomans. In 1918, the Arabs declared the **Arab Kingdom of Syria**.
- Unbeknownst to the Arabs, in 1916, Britain signed the **Sykes-Picot Agreement:** with France, proposing to partition former Ottoman territory into two spheres of influence.
- In 1917, Britain issued the **Balfour Declaration:** , proclaiming support for a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine—the first major global power to explicitly endorse Zionism. The deliberate vagueness and the phrase "national home" (with little precedence in international law) invited backlash from Arab Palestinians and anti-Zionist Jews. Britain's chief motivation was to increase Jewish support for the stalling war effort.
- By this point, Britain had promised the same territory to *three different parties*: (1) itself (Sykes-Picot), (2) the Jews (Balfour Declaration), (3) the Arabs (McMahon–Hussein correspondence).
- WWI ended in 1918; the League of Nations transferred control of Arab territories to

Britain and France. Palestine fell under **British administration** (the British Mandate for Palestine), beginning officially in 1922, though violence between Palestinian Arabs and Jews had already erupted.

British Mandate for Palestine

- The Mandate included legal protections for freedom of religion, and the League of Nations barred discrimination on the basis of ethnic or religious identity. However, de facto discrimination and segregation were common; Britain created separate institutions for Christians, Jews, and Muslims—an extension of Britain's "divide and rule" tactics.
- Throughout the 1920s–1930s, as many as 320,000 Jews emigrated to Palestine, driven by:
  1. Britain's pro-Zionist attitude encouraging migration to the historic Jewish homeland.
  2. Rising anti-Semitism (Hitler's Nazi Party, extremist sentiments in Poland, fascist movements in Eastern Europe) forcing tens of thousands to flee.
  3. Immigration caps in countries with substantial Jewish populations (especially the US), giving emigrants little choice.
  4. Ideologically-driven Jewish pioneers seeking to create self-sustaining agricultural communities.
- Jewish immigration met significant resistance, most notably:
  - The **1929 Palestine riots** (hundreds killed).
  - The **1936 Great Palestinian Revolt** (further death and a mass Palestinian strike).
- Factors contributing to growing unrest:
  1. The rising Jewish proportion gave rise to Palestinian unrest *and* a strong, unified Palestinian national identity; small-scale violence became attacks on identities, triggering escalatory retaliatory cycles.
  2. Arabs feared Britain's pro-Zionist stance (since 1917) would further limit Palestinian economic and political power as Jewish demographics grew.
  3. British imposition of foreign power structures was the most important factor. Under Ottoman rule, moderate religious leaders had peacefully coexisted. Britain's system of *political patronage* (appointing local elites rather than ruling directly) had two key implications:
     - Powerful Palestinian families (Husaynis, Nashashibis) competed for influence within institutions like the Supreme Muslim Council, creating inter-elite power struggles. Elites became increasingly extremist, giving rise to anti-Zionist rhetoric; rural Arab elites resented urban elites' monopolisation of power.
     - Historical Islamic ties between Muslim communities fractured under divide-and-rule politics, leaving Palestinian Arabs too fragmented to deal effectively with land ownership disputes.
  4. Jewish immigrants bought large tracts from foreign absentee landlords, evicting Palestinian farmers:
     - Rising Jewish population drove up property prices; wealthy Palestinian landowners sold for enormous profit.
     - Even where land was owned by *fellah* (agricultural labourer) Palestinians, the Great Depression forced them to sell to (often Jewish) bidders.
- **Note:** Conflicts were nearly always motivated by competing territorial claims and ultranationalism, not religion. Palestinians are an *ethnic group* (∼20% Christian, majority Muslim).
- Britain issued two **White Papers**:

  - **1930 White Paper:** Limited Jewish immigration; subjected Jewish land purchases to British review (intended to keep unemployment rates roughly equal).
  - **1939 White Paper:** Rejected a 1936 proposal to partition Palestine; called instead for an independent Palestinian state (doubling as a Jewish homeland) within ten years. Imposed an absolute cap on Jewish immigration for five years (by 1938, Jews were ∼30% of Palestine's population), after which Arabs would control future immigration levels. Barred Jewish land purchases in ∼95% of Palestinian territory.
  - Both sides were outraged: Jews by the immigration caps; Arabs by the ten-year delay until statehood.

The Holocaust

- The Nazi regime brutally murdered over six million European Jews and millions of other vulnerable groups (1939–1945) through pogroms, mass shootings, and extermination camps. Two-thirds of European Jews were killed—by far history's most bloody manifestation of anti-Semitism.
- The **Nuremberg Trials**: the tribunal indicted 199 people and convicted 161. The International Military Tribunal (November 1945) tried 21 of the highest-ranking Nazi war criminals. Israeli military units and vigilante Nazi hunters tracked escaped war criminals who had fled to Latin America or been granted amnesty for decades.

Formation of the Israeli State

- By 1945, every League of Nations mandatory territory except Palestine had been given independence. The League dissolved in early 1946, obfuscating Britain's legal duties. Britain declared a desire to abandon the Mandate and gave the newly-formed UN control.
- The **UN Special Committee on Palestine (UNSCOP)** faced pressure from US President Truman (who needed to court Jewish Zionist voters before the 1948 election) to support a two-state approach.
- UNSCOP proposed **Resolution 181** (late 1947): end the British Mandate, partition Palestine into two sovereign states (one Jewish, one Palestinian, Jerusalem under international control), and gradually withdraw British forces. Controversies:
  1. Palestinian Arab leaders refused to participate, arguing partition violated their right to self-determination (recently codified in the UDHR).
  2. Jews owned ∼7% of land and represented ∼30% of the population, yet the partition gave them ∼56% of the land (justified by anticipated post-WWII Jewish migration).
  3. The US pushed strongly for the partition after Zionist lobbying; nations initially opposed (e.g. Haiti) switched after US pressure (Haiti was promised a development package).
  4. The proposed Palestinian state would be ∼98% Arab; the proposed Israel would have a ∼45% Arab minority, including many majority-Arab towns.
- In November 1947, the UN narrowly passed Resolution 181:
  - **Jewish reaction:** Highly supportive. After centuries of oppression, a nation of their own—especially after the Holocaust. Ultra-nationalist radicals (e.g. paramilitary Lehi) opposed it, but most Jews celebrated.
  - **Arab reaction:** Deep frustration; overwhelming rejection as an encroachment upon sovereignty and self-determination. Arab League states and Muslim-majority nations (e.g. Pakistan) denounced it. Pakistan and India stormed out of the UN in protest. Syrian President al-Quwatli announced "we shall eradicate Zionism"; the Arab League General Secretary affirmed a desire to "sweep" Jews "into the sea."

First Arab-Israeli War, Part One: Civil War (1947–1948)

- The passage of Resolution 181 triggered conflict between the Jewish state and Palestine (backed by regional Arab nations). The war had two phases: the ethno-communal civil war phase and the regional invasion phase.
- The civil war began the day after the partition was announced. Paramilitary groups on both sides engaged in guerrilla campaigns and de facto terrorism: car bombings, targeted assassinations, snipers firing on pedestrians. Palestinians sought to halt the partition; Jews sought control over land allotted to them.
- By January 1948, the conflict became increasingly militarised:
  - **Zionist forces:** Haganah (aided by Irgun and Lehi). Many paramilitary groups originated from the pre-1947 Jewish insurgency against British rule, supporting *Revisionist Zionism* (full Jewish control over Eretz Yisrael, the largest biblical expanse of Israel per the Torah).
  - **Palestinian forces:** Arab Liberation Army and the Arab High Committee's Holy War Army.
- Foreign support:
  - Zionist militias received little initial Western political support (the US feared an Arab oil embargo). Most weapons were acquired through **Operation Balak**, an illegal smuggling operation; munitions were mostly produced/supplied by Czechoslovakia in conjunction with the Soviet Union. Stalin believed Israel would turn socialist and become a Soviet sphere of influence. Czechoslovakia needed income because it could not access Marshall Plan funding. Tomáš Masaryk, Czechoslovakia's co-founder and first president, was an ardent Zionist supporter.
  - Zionist militias also received grassroots funding from wealthy donors in the US and Western Europe.
  - The Arab League promised substantial funding to Palestinian militias, but most never materialised; the only true support came from Syria.
- British soldiers seldom intervened despite numerous massacres by both sides—e.g. the **Deir Yassin massacre** (Jewish forces slaughtered 107 Arab-Palestinian civilians, mostly women and children) and the **Kfar Etzion massacre** (Arab forces killed 129 peaceful resident Jews).
- The civil war phase ended May 14, 1948, when Britain removed its last forces and the Mandate officially ended.

First Arab-Israeli War, Part Two: Invasion (1948–1949)

- Following the end of the Mandate, Zionist Jews declared Israel's independence. Arab states rejected it; the next night, neighbouring countries launched air strikes against Tel Aviv (originally Israel's capital; Jerusalem became the capital in 1949) and prepared for ground invasion.
- Motivations for the Arab invasion:
  1. Arab states viewed Israel as a violation of self-determination and a de facto Western puppet.
  2. Fear that ongoing strife could infiltrate the broader region and catalyse instability; concern about a refugee crisis eroding borders.
- A coalition of Arab League members—Lebanon, Syria, Iraq, Egypt, with Saudi military backing—launched a ground invasion. The invasion was denounced by the US, Soviet Union, and UN, but supported by some nations (e.g. China).

- Early weeks saw significant Arab territorial gains, but Israeli forces resisted due to strong morale and foreign weapons. As the war dragged on, Israeli attitudes shifted:
  1. Israeli leaders genuinely viewed the invasion as a potential re-enactment of the Holocaust in the Middle East, invigorated by intensely anti-Israel Arab rhetoric.
  2. As defensive operations succeeded, Israel sought to expand borders to include Jewish communities excluded from the partition—motivated by both limiting the Arab minority (perceived as hostile) and making borders more defensible.
  3. Extremism on both sides made peace nearly impossible: e.g. Swedish diplomat Count Folke Bernadotte proposed a new partition (giving Arab refugees right of return plus territorial concessions to Israel); Jewish ultra-nationalists assassinated him despite his having negotiated the release of hundreds of Jews from concentration camps during WWII.
- **Outcome:** Israel expanded to occupy nearly one-third more land than originally given under the partition. ∼60% of territory originally designated for Palestinians fell under Israeli control. Transjordan (modern Jordan, renamed 1949) annexed the West Bank and East Jerusalem; Egypt took the Gaza Strip.
- **Why Israel won**—beyond the simplified narrative of Jewish courage:
  1. **Arab disunity:** Fragmented leadership with irreconcilably conflicting goals. King Abdullah I of Transjordan had a secret pact with Zionist leaders (West Bank to Transjordan if they did not interfere with Israeli territory). Other Arab leaders grew suspicious, desiring a more total defeat. By contrast, Ben-Gurion unified Zionist militias into the centralised IDF.
  2. **Weak Palestinian leadership:** Many Palestinian elites had fled during the 1936–39 revolt, creating an unfilled leadership vacuum. Palestinian agriculture was in dismal shape (Jewish land consolidation, destruction of farms).
  3. **Growing Israeli military strength:**
     - A surge of Jewish emigration expanded recruitment; mandatory conscription ensured steady deployments.
     - Greater inflows of foreign weapons: despite a UN arms embargo, Israel's underground smuggling network proved more adept at circumventing sanctions. A powerful Jewish crime boss in Miami helped reroute arms through Panama (not yet a UN Charter party), bypassing the embargo. The Jewish mafia played a crucial role in facilitating illegal arms exports from Central/Eastern Europe and the US.
     - During temporary ceasefires, Arab states bickered over post-war spoils while Israel (with a more unified goal) replenished forces through extensive training. Israel benefited far more from ceasefires than the Arabs.

Implications: Nakba, Borders, and Hebraization

- The war ended in 1949 with armistice agreements. The UN passed **Resolution 194**, endorsing Palestinians' "right of return"—activists argue this provides a legal basis for Palestinian claims to statehood.
- **Territorial outcomes:** Israel definitively established as a Jewish state with borders dwarfing the original partition. Egypt assumed control of Gaza; Jordan controlled the West Bank and East Jerusalem. Mass Jewish emigration to Israel from around the world followed.
- **Demographic effects (Nakba):** ∼700,000 Palestinian Arabs displaced, forced into neighbouring countries or refugee camps (most run by UNRWA). Nearly 500 Palestinian

villages were destroyed, repopulated by Israeli Jews, and subject to **Hebraization:** (replacing Palestinian town names with Hebrew names).

- **Nakba:** ("disaster"): Millions of Palestinians remain refugees, generating pressure for Israel to recognise the *right of return*—the right of displaced refugees to return to their homeland.
- **Competing narratives:** To Jews, the **War of Independence**—a safe haven from anti-Semitism and the culmination of Herzl's Zionism. To Palestinians, the **Nakba**—a catastrophe for self-determination; to the broader Arab world, a devastating blow.

Interwar Period: Skirmishes and Political Antagonism

- Despite armistices, smaller-scale violence accelerated. Two main groups: the Palestinian **fedayeen:** (guerrilla fighters who conducted campaigns from refugee camps and Arab-controlled provinces) and the IDF (which established reprisal units, most famously **Unit 101**).
- A devastating, self-perpetuating cycle of violence:
  - **1953 Qibya massacre:** Israeli forces (under future PM Ariel Sharon) murdered 69 Palestinian villagers, destroyed 45 houses, burned a school and a mosque.
  - **Ma'ale Akrabim massacre:** Palestinian militants ambushed an Israeli passenger bus and massacred 12 Jewish civilians.
- Diplomatic hostility driven by four factors:
  1. The Arab League maintained bitter opposition to Israel's existence after their humiliating defeat.
  2. Palestinian militants organised from Israel's bordering neighbours (especially Gaza under Egyptian control), prompting Israeli operations in Jordan, Syria, and Egypt.
  3. **Water politics:** Disputes over the Jordan River and the Arab League's opposition to Israel's **National Water Carrier** (completed 1964) led to border disputes. The Arab League feared an economically developed Israel.
  4. The Arab League maintained and strengthened its boycott against Israel throughout the 1950s. Some nations still maintain it (Syria, Iran, Sudan, Lebanon), though its contemporary effect on Israel's economy is minimal.

Suez Crisis: Second Arab-Israeli War (1956)

- **Background on the Suez Canal:** An artificially-built naval passage in Egypt; the shortest link between the Mediterranean and Indian Ocean, enabling speedy Europe–Asia trade. Also of military importance (during WWI, Britain/France barred non-Allied vessels).
  - In 1875, Britain assumed a 44% ownership stake (majority held by private French investors). By the 1950s, nearly two-thirds of Europe's oil supply ran through the Canal.
  - Post-WWII, Egyptian sentiment towards Britain soured. Reasons: Britain's support for Zionism, expanded Middle Eastern influence (even as Britain decolonised elsewhere), rising inflation/unemployment, growing influence of radical Islamist organisations (Muslim Brotherhood), and the "Black Friday" anti-British protests in Cairo (11 British citizens killed).
  - The **Egyptian Revolution of 1952** overthrew the monarchy; **Gamal Abdel Nasser** rose to power. Nasser was an Egyptian nationalist who cracked down on the Muslim Brotherhood, gained a cult of personality through land redistribution and socialist policies, and was fiercely anti-Zionist. He viewed Iraq and Jordan as

competing regional hegemons.
  - Nasser formed a secret defensive military pact with Jordan by stoking protests in Amman to make King Hussein fear for his power, leading Jordan to dismiss British officers from its military.
- **Cold War dynamics:**
  - Stalin's death (1953) and Khrushchev's rise reoriented Soviet foreign policy: rather than demonise non-aligned states, the USSR courted their favour (arms deals, development packages).
  - The US faced difficulties competing: the 1950 Tripartite Declaration (US, Britain, France) upheld 1948 borders, limiting US weapon sales. Egypt refused to promise US-supplied arms would not be used against Israel, and the Jewish-Israeli lobby opposed any Egypt–US arms deal. This gave the USSR a "blank check."
  - Egypt entered a $83M arms deal with the Soviets (1955), routed through Czechoslovakia.
  - Eisenhower pushed for Egypt–Israel peace, but Nasser refused to negotiate, cementing Egypt's position as an Arab leader through aggressive anti-Zionism.
- **Nationalisation and invasion:** In July 1956, Nasser nationalised the Suez Canal, blocked Israeli vessels, and maintained the blockade of the Straits of Tiran (connecting the Gulf of Aqaba to the Red Sea). This may have constituted a crime of aggression under international law.
- After secret negotiations, Israel—backed by British and French militaries—invaded Egypt (Israeli invasion of Sinai, British aerial strikes, European paratroopers). Egyptian military disarray (high-ranking posts filled through loyalty to Nasser, not merit) allowed Israel to advance within ten miles of the Canal in two days.
- **Ceasefire:** Britain announced a ceasefire in November 1956, driven by:
  1. Domestic unpopularity: Egyptian nationalisation had occurred months prior, and British anger had faded.
  2. US pressure—several factors:
     - Britain had kept American intelligence in the dark about invasion planning.
     - The USSR was simultaneously involved in the 1956 Hungarian Revolution; supporting the invasion while condemning Soviet intervention would look hypocritical.
     - Failing to condemn Britain would sully America's image in the oil-rich Middle East, advantaging the USSR.
     - The Soviet Union threatened nuclear retaliation against Western Europe; Eisenhower condemned the rhetoric but Soviet aggression was arguably crucial in pressuring resolution.
  3. US economic threats: threatened a fire-sale of gilt-edged English securities; when Britain sought IMF support (facing an oil crisis and dwindling reserves), the US used its disproportionate IMF influence to block assistance.
- **Outcome:** No clear victor. A military victory for British/French/Israeli forces on paper, but Egypt regained control of the Canal. The British PM was forced to resign; Britain's reputation as a global empire effectively ended; decolonisation accelerated across Asia and Africa.
- **Global implications:** The USSR's brinkmanship was touted by Khrushchev as responsible for the war's resolution. The crisis provided partial cover for Soviet repression of Hungary. Egypt reframed its performance as a triumph over Zionism and Western colonialism; Nasser's popularity surged.

- **For Israel:** Israeli vessels gained freedom of passage through the Straits of Tiran (denied since 1948). UNEF peacekeepers were stationed along the Israeli-Egyptian border (though Israel refused UN personnel inside its territory). Domestically, Israel framed the war as a victory, though this was contested even within the Knesset.

Palestinian Organising and the PLO

- In 1964, the Arab League met at a summit in Cairo and decided to create the **Palestinian Liberation Organization (PLO):** .
- Yasser Arafat founded/led the PLO, which used both violent and nonviolent means.

Third Arab-Israeli War: Six-Day War (1967)

- In 1967, the **Six-Day War** resulted in a decisive Israeli victory. Israel gained control over the **West Bank**, the **Gaza Strip**, the **Golan Heights**, and the **Sinai Peninsula**.
- **UN Resolution 242:** Established a basic framework for peace—Israel to withdraw from occupied territory; all parties to recognise the rights of both a Palestinian and an Israeli state.
- After the war, the conflict morphed from a broader Arab–Israeli conflict into primarily an Israeli–Palestinian conflict.
- **Important distinction:** Not all Muslims are Arabs; not all Arabs are Palestinians; not all Palestinians are Muslims (Palestinians are an ethnic identity; $\sim$20% are Christians).

Israeli Settlements

- After the Six-Day War, the Israeli government began building settlements in East Jerusalem, the Gaza Strip, and the West Bank.
- 350,000+ settlers in the West Bank; 200,000+ in East Jerusalem.

First Intifada and Hamas

- **1980s: First Intifada**—Boycotts of Israel; IDF cracked down; violence ensued.
- **Hamas:** launched its first suicide bombing in 1993. Hamas gained popularity not only through militancy but also through *social welfare projects* (schools, mosques, clinics, etc.).

Oslo Accords and Peace Talks

- The **Oslo Accords** represented the emergence of peace talks, but many issues remained unresolved: right of return, water rights, and other core disputes.

Second Intifada

- **September 2000:** Ariel Sharon led a march to the Temple Mount (the third holiest site in Islam, the holiest site in Judaism) with 1,000 armed guards—a deeply provocative act.
- This triggered the **Second Intifada** (3,000 Palestinians killed).
- **2002:** Israel began construction of a wall/barrier around the West Bank, built to include many Israeli settlements. Debate: self-defence measure or illegal land grab?

Post-Arafat Period

- Arafat died in 2005; Hamas subsequently won a majority of parliamentary seats.
- Hamas vs. the Palestinian Authority; Hamas launched rocket attacks into Israel.

Core Arguments in the Conflict

- **Palestinian argument:** Denied statehood for decades; living under military occupation.
- **Israeli argument:** Need a homeland; are not the first nation to consolidate/increase territory; must protect their nation.
- At its heart: *competing nationalist visions.*

Russia and Vladimir Putin

Russia's Historical Context

- Following the Russian Revolution and the Bolshevik Red Army's victory in the Russian Civil War, **Vladimir Lenin** rose to power within the newly-formed Soviet Union. After Lenin's death in 1924, **Joseph Stalin** became General Secretary and de facto dictator.
- Lenin's "New Economic Policy" had seen partial emergence of free-market principles; Stalin pursued heavy *industrialisation and collectivisation*, resulting in substantial economic growth but enormous humanitarian crisis (millions died of famine).
- Stalin imposed brutally totalitarian rule, cracking down on even the slightest opposition. The **Great Purge:** (Great Terror) saw executions of hundreds of thousands and the use of secret police (NKVD, KGB). Stalin was so paranoid he allegedly had police monitor public speeches to identify who stopped applauding first, so he could have them killed. He even ordered the execution of NKVD leaders after ordering them to carry out mass killings.
- Under subsequent Soviet leaders, policy varied. As the Cold War neared its end, **Mikhail Gorbachev** (leader from 1985) pursued reforms:
  - Nuclear non-proliferation treaties with the US under Reagan.
  - **Glasnost:** : drastically expanded free speech rights.
  - **Perestroika:** : decentralised economic decision-making; incorporated free-market principles.
- In 1989, the Berlin Wall was torn down. In 1991, the Soviet Union collapsed, driven by ethnic separatism within Soviet republics (resenting repressive control), economic stagnation, and political fragmentation.
- Following dissolution, Russia lost nearly half its population and a third of its territory. The process plunged Russia into deep recession, compounded by privatisation of ∼45,000 state-owned enterprises. President **Boris Yeltsin** attempted *voucher privatisation*, but control fell into the hands of a small number of powerful businessmen and oil tycoons ("New Russians")—the well-known base of Russian oligarchs—who capitalised on the chaotic transition.

Rise of Vladimir Putin

- At the time of the Soviet collapse, Putin was working for the KGB, where he developed admiration for Soviet strength and glory. Post-1991, he rose to head the FSB (the KGB's successor).
- Yeltsin was widely disliked: cozy with the US abroad, but too little done to mitigate economic crisis at home (his own Vice President accused his policies of "economic genocide"). In mid-1999, Putin was appointed Prime Minister.
- Putin developed a strong, militaristic stance against Chechen separatists during the Second Chechen War; this law-and-order image boosted his reputation.
- When Yeltsin unexpectedly resigned on the eve of January 2000, Putin assumed the presidency. He won the March 2000 elections with 53% of votes.

- Putin established an implicit *quid pro quo* with oligarchs: comply with his demands and retain wealth/power. But those perceived as threats were crushed—e.g. **Mikhail Khodorkovsky** (billionaire, head of Yukos Oil Company), who started a pro-democracy/civil rights movement ("Open Russia") in 2001. Putin manipulated Yukos's tax and legal obligations; Russia's Putin-allied justice system announced trumped-up charges, resulting in Khodorkovsky's exile.
- Putin's early political popularity was consistently improved by national security crises:
  - Crackdown on Chechen Muslims solidified his status as a viable national figure.
  - October 2002: Islamist separatists' mass hostage crisis at a Russian theatre—Putin's approval neared 80% after most hostages were rescued.
  - 2004 Beslan school siege: terrorists took hundreds hostage. Putin used the ensuing panic to consolidate power (making formerly elected positions appointed by the executive), pass strict anti-terror laws expanding law enforcement discretion, and crack down on foreign media.
- Putin continued cracking down on independent media:
  - 2006: Independent journalist Anna Politkovskaya killed under mysterious circumstances; Western states accused Russia.
  - Putin's United Russia party continued surging in popularity.
- In 2008, constitutionally barred from a third consecutive term, Putin became Prime Minister—but in his last days as President, he realigned bureaucratic agencies to report to the PM rather than the President.
- Anti-Putin sentiment festered, especially after disputed/rigged 2011 elections. Pussy Riot's illegal performance in a Russian Orthodox cathedral symbolised opposition, but counter-protests in support of Putin also erupted.

Navalny

- Putin consolidated power by bringing media under state control, rigging elections (manipulating who could run), and weeding out opposing oligarchs (arresting Khodorkovsky and Boris Berezovsky on trumped-up embezzlement charges; playing a role in the killing of Nikolay Glushkov). Corruption flourished: an estimated $427 billion lost to corruption between 2000 and 2008.
- **2006: Alexei Navalny** began a blog exposing Putin's corruption, publishing leaked documents and circumventing state media restrictions.
- **2011:** After United Russia won elections through fraud and rigging, protests swept the country. Navalny played a large role in leading and organising them. Thousands of protesters were arrested; many leaders were jailed, secretly killed, or forced into exile.
- **2013:** Navalny declared his campaign for Mayor of Moscow. State TV gave no airtime, so he relied on social media. Shortly before the election, he was arrested on false embezzlement charges; significant pushback led to his release on bail. He finished an impressive second place behind the Kremlin-endorsed Sergey Sobyanin.
- Navalny set up a YouTube channel exposing government corruption; videos viewed tens of millions of times. He became the most recognised figure of the Russian opposition.
- **2016:** Navalny announced his presidential candidacy but was barred due to past embezzlement charges, despite the European Court of Human Rights siding with him. He reapplied in December 2017 but was rejected again.
- **"Smart voting" strategy:** Putin rigs elections not by outright disallowing opposition but by splintering the opposition vote. Navalny advocated for dissatisfied voters to vote as a monolith for a single opposition candidate. This represented a serious threat to Putin's

chokehold on power.

- **2020:** Putin credibly rumoured to have ordered Navalny's assassination. While aboard a flight, Navalny became seriously ill—poisoned with **novichok**, a toxic chemical developed by Soviet biologists during the Cold War. After recovery, Navalny tricked the responsible agent into explaining the attack in detail, recorded the exchange, and posted it online.
- **January 2021:** Navalny returned to Russia, was immediately arrested and imprisoned. His team released a video revealing one of Putin's secret "palaces," inspiring widespread protests.

The European Union (EU)

EU Institutions

European Council

- **Structure:** Acts as the EU's collective presidency. Meets ∼4 times annually. National leaders (heads of state/government) represent each Member State. The President is selected by the other representatives.
- **Power:** Sets the EU's policy agenda, amends EU treaties, resolves policy disputes—but *lacks formal legislative power*. Appoints the President of the European Commission and the President of the ECB. Confirms nominated members of the European Commission.

European Commission

- **Structure:** Each nation has one seat. Each Commissioner is responsible for one policy area (e.g. agriculture, fishing). The President delegates policy areas. The European Council appoints the President, who reviews approved candidates from each nation. The European Parliament and European Council must approve nominations through a "qualified majority." Commissioners represent *EU interests, not national interests*.
- **Power:** De facto executive body. Proposes legislation and monitors enforcement of binding EU legislation within national governments. Designs/plans the EU budget (subject to approval by the Council of the EU and the European Parliament).

European Parliament

- **Structure:** MEPs are directly elected every five years via proportional representation. Power is allocated roughly proportional to population. Once elected, MEPs organise by *political affiliation, not nationality*.
- **Power:** Does *not* initiate legislation (all legislation comes from the European Commission). Has joint power with the Council of the EU to vote on proposed legislation. Approves nominations for the European Commission (including its President).

Council of the European Union

- **Structure:** National ministers represent governments. Different ministers evaluate laws based on subject area (e.g. finance ministers for economic legislation).
- **Power:** The "upper house" of the EU legislative body; passes laws in conjunction with the European Parliament.

Court of Justice of the European Union (CJEU)

- Interprets EU law to ensure uniform application across all EU countries; settles legal disputes between national governments and EU institutions. Can be used by individuals, companies, or organisations if their rights have been infringed.
- Three judicial entities:
  1. **European Court of Justice (ECJ):** Ensures EU law is followed and Treaties are correctly interpreted/applied; reviews legality of EU institutional acts; ensures Member State compliance; interprets EU law at national courts' request.
  2. **General Court:** Initial "trial court" for EU legal disputes. Decisions can be appealed to the ECJ.
  3. **Civil Service Tribunal:** Resolves disputes between the EU and European civil service members. In rare cases, the ECJ can hear these cases.

European Central Bank (ECB)

- Of 28 EU members, only 19 are in the eurozone; only those 19 provide input to ECB leadership. The UK was never in the eurozone (uses GBP).
- **Structure:** All members appointed by the European Council by qualified majority for non-renewable eight-year terms.
- **Power:** Primary objective is to maintain price stability and keep inflation low. Executive Board members act in the interests of the eurozone as a whole, not any particular Member State. EU institutions and national governments are treaty-bound to respect ECB independence.

EU Competences

The EU has competence (authority) to pass binding legislation if three criteria are met:

1. **Conferral:** The EU has only authority conferred by EU treaties ratified by all member countries.
2. **Proportionality:** EU action cannot exceed what is necessary to achieve treaty objectives.
3. **Subsidiarity:** Where either the EU or national governments can act, the EU may intervene only if it can act more effectively.

Exclusive competence (EU alone can pass laws; member states cannot):

- Customs union
- Competition rules for the single market
- Monetary policy for eurozone countries
- Trade and international agreements (only if affecting the entirety of the EU and negotiated/ratified by the EU Commission)
- Marine plants and animals (common fisheries policy)

Shared competence (both EU and member countries can pass laws, but members only if the EU has not already proposed laws or decided not to):

- Single market; economic, social and territorial cohesion; consumer protection; trans-European networks and transport; energy; research and space; agriculture, fisheries, environment
- Employment and social affairs (within TFEU confines: promote employment, improve living/working conditions, provide social protection, combat social exclusion); development cooperation and humanitarian aid

- Justice and fundamental rights; migration and home affairs; public health (aspects defined in Article 168, TFEU)

Supporting competence (EU can only support, coordinate, or complement; cannot pass laws or interfere with member countries' ability to do so):

- Public health, industry, culture, tourism, education and training, youth and sport, civil protection, administrative cooperation

EU Voting

- **Qualified majority voting:** Requires 55% of representative votes and 65% of the EU electorate.
- **Unanimity voting:** Requires complete agreement. Limited to:
  - Common foreign and security policy (with exceptions requiring qualified majority, e.g. appointment of a special representative).
  - The **Common Security and Defence Policy (CSDP):** : provides the EU with operational capacity to deploy civilian and military missions abroad (conflict prevention, peacekeeping, crisis management, joint disarmament, military advice, humanitarian/rescue tasks, post-conflict stabilisation). First EU missions launched in 2003 (policing in Bosnia and Herzegovina, military operation in North Macedonia). Since then, 36 operations/missions on three continents; 17 ongoing (11 civilian, 6 military).
  - Citizenship (granting new rights to EU citizens).
  - EU membership.
  - Harmonisation of national legislation on indirect taxation (including VAT).
  - EU finances (own resources, multiannual financial framework).
  - Certain justice and home affairs provisions (European prosecutor, family law, operational police cooperation, etc.).
  - Harmonisation of national legislation on social security and social protection.

EU Enlargement

- To join the EU, a country must meet the **Copenhagen Criteria:** : free-market economy, stable democracy and rule of law, acceptance of all EU legislation (including the euro). Political criteria are most important: universal suffrage, free elections, free press, independent judiciary, minority protections. Applicants must join and ratify the European Convention on Human Rights.
- **Three stages of membership:**
  1. **Official candidate status.** Current candidates: Albania (applied April 2009, candidate June 2014), North Macedonia (candidate December 2005; ascension conditional on Pržino agreement—opposition participation, caretaker government, PM Gruevski stepping down), Montenegro (applied December 2008, candidate December 2010), Turkey (candidate December 1999, negotiations opened October 2005), Serbia (applied December 2009, candidate March 2012).
  2. **Membership negotiations:** Adoption of EU law into national law (judicial, administrative, economic reforms). All current EU member states must agree to the accession treaty.
  3. **Accession:** The candidate has met all criteria and joins the EU.

EU Expansionism in the Balkans

- The **Stabilisation and Association Process (SAP):** is the EU's policy towards the Western Balkans, established with the aim of eventual EU membership. Western Balkan countries are involved in a progressive partnership for regional stabilisation and a free-trade area.
- Since 2000, the EU has granted autonomous trade preferences to all Western Balkans (renewed end of 2020), allowing nearly all exports to enter the EU without customs duties or quantity limits. Exceptions: sugar, wine, baby beef, and certain fisheries products (preferential tariff quotas).
- Bilateral FTAs (**Stabilisation and Association Agreements:** , SAAs) concluded with: Albania (2009), North Macedonia (2004), Montenegro (2010), Serbia (2013), Bosnia and Herzegovina (2015), Kosovo (2016).
- SAAs provide for economic development and political stabilisation, creating a close, long-term association between the EU and the Western Balkans. They constitute the legal instrument for alignment to the EU *acquis* (accumulated legislation, legal acts, and court decisions constituting the body of EU law) and progressive integration into the EU market.

Ukraine and NATO

Context

- During the Soviet era, Ukraine was the second most populous Soviet state, with deep political, economic, and social connections to the USSR. After the 1991 collapse, Ukraine became independent, oscillating between pro-Western and pro-Russian foreign policy.
- **Western Ukraine:** More nationalist, Ukrainian-speaking population favouring connections with the West (US alliance, NATO membership, EU integration).
- **Eastern Ukraine:** Largely Russian-speaking communities favouring ties with Russia.
- **2014:** Ukraine's President rejected a proposed agreement increasing political/economic ties with the EU. Protests erupted; the pro-Russian President was ousted by parliament. He called upon Russia, which did not recognise the interim pro-Western government.
- Russia invaded; intense fighting in the eastern **Donbas region**. Two self-proclaimed pro-Russian proto-states emerged: the **Donetsk People's Republic** and the **Luhansk People's Republic**.
- **Annexation of Crimea (2014):** Russia deployed "little green men" (unmarked Russian forces without identification or insignia) throughout Crimean political centres. After bloodlessly infiltrating Crimea, Russia held a *rigged referendum* in which Crimea ostensibly voted overwhelmingly to join the Russian Federation.
- **Putin's motivations:**
  - Fear of Western political/military expansion near Russia's borders.
  - Multi-generational familial ties between Russia and Crimea.
  - Kyiv is often called the "mother of Russian cities."
  - Desire to expand the Russian state to regain the glory of the Soviet Union (*revanchism*).
- Putin publicly demanded that NATO permanently refuse future bids for Ukrainian membership and withdraw military forces from Eastern Europe.

The 2022 Invasion

- **February 21:** Russian forces moved into the Donbas, ostensibly for "peacekeeping."

- **February 22:** The upper house of the Russian legislature voted unanimously to authorise military force outside Russia's borders. Russia formally recognised the Donetsk and Luhansk People's Republics.
- **February 24:** After months of military build-up, Russia launched a full invasion. Putin declared a "special military operation" in the Donbas; Russian air strikes began within minutes. Russia moved towards Kyiv and allegedly blocked the city from the west.
- **Ukrainian response:** Martial law declared; Ukrainian men aged 18–60 required to remain in-country; thousands of volunteers offered military services; the government distributed nearly 20,000 guns to reserve forces in the Kyiv region. President Zelenskyy remained in Kyiv, delivering periodic streamed addresses. On the evening of February 25, he said: "This night will be very difficult, and the enemy will use all available forces to break the resistance of Ukrainians... the fate of Ukraine is being decided right now."
- **Military dynamics:** As of late February 25, no major population centres taken. Western intelligence indicated the initial invasion was slowing. Russia captured the Chernobyl zone (February 24); workers held hostage. Russia's initial invasion featured heavy use of Soviet-era technology rather than more sophisticated available weaponry; ∼75% of amassed Russian forces had not yet been deployed. Analysts speculated Russia aimed to absorb Ukraine's anti-air and anti-tank missiles with outdated equipment before deploying advanced machinery.
- **International military aid:** Poland was the first to publicly provide ammunition. The US Pentagon delivered military aid (details withheld for security). Biden promised to back Ukraine but firmly denied American boots on the ground. British NLAW anti-tank missiles proved vitally important for Ukrainian forces.

Immediate International Response

- Widespread international condemnation from virtually every major Western leader.
- **UNSC:** Moved to condemn the invasion, but the motion was *vetoed by Russia* (permanent veto power; Russia held the UNSC Presidency for February). China (close Russian ally) abstained.
- **Sanctions:** Western nations imposed a range of sanctions on the Russian economy, financial sector, and specific political/economic elites. The US and Canada declared intent to impose targeted sanctions on Putin himself (including freezing financial assets).
- **NATO:** Vowed to "do what it takes" to defend Eastern European member states. **NATO Response Force (NRF)**—special units from NATO and allied countries (including Finland, Ukraine, Georgia)—activated for the first time in NATO history; selective units deployed to Eastern Europe.
- **SWIFT controversy:** Powerful Western nations (including the US) had not initially agreed to cut Russia off from SWIFT (Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication): an electronic financial messaging system run by two dozen Western central banks (including the US Federal Reserve). Over 11,000 banks use SWIFT for 42 million transactions daily. Cutting Russia off could cripple its economy by up to 5% of GDP, primarily by denying the ability to sell natural gas and oil to Europe.
  - **Concerns:** Economic harm to European nations dependent on Russian gas. Russia's alternative banking system, **SFPS** (developed 2014), could gain traction. Russia discussed a joint Russian-Chinese banking alternative to SWIFT.
- Ukrainian airspace locked down; European aviation officials expanded the lockdown due to missile fears.

China: History of the Chinese Communist Party

Ancient History and the Fall of the Qing Dynasty

- For nearly three thousand years, China was ruled by dynastic, hereditary monarchies (mostly Han Chinese). By the 19th century, the Qing dynasty was besieged by internal divisions and weakened by foreign powers (Japan, Britain).
- **1899: Boxer Rebellion**—Pro-Qing Chinese nationalists, opposed to colonial control, waged a futile attempt to drive out colonial powers; the rebellion failed and further weakened the Qing.
- The Qing implemented political, educational, and military reforms (extending the Self-Strengthening Movement from after the Anglo-Chinese Opium Wars, which pushed for Westernisation of China's military and economic structures). This failed: Confucian conservatives condemned the reforms as radical; reform-minded activists viewed them as too little, too late.
- **1911: Xinhai Revolution**—Overthrew imperial rule; began incidentally (unintentional bomb detonation), but large military factions mutinied (resenting lack of modernisation) and joined the rebels. By early 1912, the last emperor **Aisin-Gioro Puyi** abdicated; a new government formed under military general **Yuan Shikai**.
- After Yuan's death (1916), the government collapsed, and the **Warlord Era:** saw competing military cliques fight for power.

The United Fronts and the Chinese Civil War

- The **First United Front** emerged between:
  - The **KMT:** (Kuomintang / Chinese Nationalist Party): endorsed strong Chinese nationalism; disavowed Marxism.
  - The **CCP:** (Communist Party of China): founded 1921; advocated Soviet/Russian-style Bolshevik communism to uplift the rural working-class poor.
- In 1927, the KMT purged CCP officials; the Nationalists succeeded in uniting China and proclaimed the **Republic of China**. The **Chinese Civil War** began.
- During WWII, the KMT and CCP formed the **Second United Front** to fight invading Japanese/Axis Powers. After Japan's defeat and the collapse of its puppet government, the civil war resumed (1945–1949): the **Chinese Communist Revolution**.
- The CCP's People's Liberation Army defeated the KMT. Chinese Nationalists were exiled to **Taiwan**; the Communists under **Mao Zedong** proclaimed the **People's Republic of China**.

China Under Mao

- Mao consolidated power through land redistribution to peasants and the **Yan'an Rectification Movement** (cracking down on CCP enemies, attacking the power of intellectuals, instilling Communist ideas).
- After 1949, Mao became de facto dictator. China ostensibly promised civil, political, and human rights (including women's equality and intellectual freedoms), but in practice ruled with an iron fist:
  - **Three-anti and Five-anti Campaigns:** Persecuted thousands for corruption or association with capitalism.
  - **Socialist Education Movement, Anti-Rightist Campaign, Sufan Movement:** Mass purges of capitalists, ideological adversaries, corrupt officials, right-wing supporters, and KMT sympathisers.

- These measures, combined with propaganda, solidified Mao's cult of personality.

The Great Leap Forward (1958–1962)

- Under Marxist-Leninist principles, China pursued a Soviet-style command economy with Five Year Plans (first in 1953; renamed "guidelines" after China's transition to a mixed-market economy).
- The Great Leap Forward attempted to radically restructure from subsistence agriculture to industrialised manufacturing. Private agriculture was banned; all farms operated under collectivisation. The result: the **worst famine in human history**—an estimated 45 million people starved to death.
- **Factors contributing to failure:**
  1. *Egotistical irrationality:* After the 1956 Sino-Soviet split over ideological fractures, Mao desperately sought to demonstrate the superiority of China's "pure communism" over Khrushchev's post-Stalinist reorientation, demanding ever-higher production quotas.
  2. *Falsified reporting:* Local officials lied about production levels to avoid humiliation or execution; this made central planners overconfident, causing them to raise targets to unsustainable levels.
  3. *Perverse incentives:* Workers were compensated with little regard to output, creating a disincentive to work and contributing to food shortages.
  4. *Materials shortages and miscoordination:* Centrally-planned industrialisation led to failures such as thousands of backyard furnaces that could only produce low-quality crude "pig" iron.
  5. *Ineffective farming practices:* Officials overseeing agricultural collectives were often unsuited. Most infamously, China attempted to exterminate sparrows (making millions of peasants clang pots and pans until birds dropped dead), believing they consumed grain; this backfired as locusts (normally kept in check by sparrows) swarmed and destroyed farmland. Additionally, relocating millions of men to urban steel-producing facilities left gruelling agricultural work to women, children, and the elderly.
- The Great Leap Forward was called off by 1962, having largely failed to invigorate the economy.

The Cultural Revolution (1966)

- Mao launched the Cultural Revolution to reassert control over the CCP and inspire China's youth to rid the country of "impure" elements. The central goal: eliminate the **Four Olds:** (old customs, old culture, old habits, old ideas).
- Mao widely distributed his *Little Red Book* (speeches and essays; millions of copies printed and distributed to the peasantry).
- Students formed paramilitary groups (**Red Guards**) that violently attacked intellectuals. High-ranking leaders (e.g. President Liu Shaoqi) were purged and executed. Cultural artefacts were destroyed; thousands killed in public spectacles of murder; cities plunged into near-anarchy as factionalism erupted.
- The **Down to the Countryside Movement** forcibly relocated millions of privileged urban youth to poor rural provinces to rid them of pro-bourgeois mindsets.

Reform Under Deng Xiaoping

- After Mao's rule ended in the late 1970s, reform-minded centrist **Deng Xiaoping** (a former target of Mao's purges) outmanoeuvred other CCP leaders. He was impressed by Singapore's technocratic governance.
- Deng privately disavowed Mao's obsession with ideological purity, pursuing *realpolitik* economic pragmatism.
- **Economic reforms:** Replaced the Maoist command economy with **socialism with Chinese characteristics:** :
  - De-collectivised agriculture; liberalised the economy (greater foreign capital inflows, private enterprises, the **Chengbao system:** —partially privatising state firms by leasing services to private enterprises in exchange for royalties; the largest SOEs in petroleum and finance were unaffected).
  - By the mid-1980s: price controls lifted, protectionist trade barriers revoked, regional trade agreements forged, deregulation pursued. Special economic zones created (e.g. Shenzhen). Pursued WTO membership (China joined 2001).
  - Result: staggeringly high growth rates, often exceeding 9% annually.
- **Social/cultural reforms (Boluan Fanzheng):** Reversed anti-establishment Cultural Revolution momentum. Constitution significantly revised, CCP structure reformed, gaokao university entrance exam restored (Deng also mandated nine-year education for all children), intellectualism rehabilitated.
- **Demographic policy:** Strict one-child policy to curb explosive population growth (tightened from earlier Mao-era controls).
- **Political/diplomatic reforms:** Normalised relations with the US; proposed the **One Country, Two Systems:** principle (later applied to Macau and Hong Kong); pursued Constitutional revisions and term limits.
- **Controversies:** Backlash from Mao supporters; economic liberalisation exacerbated inequality, raising questions about China's communist status. Internationally, Deng's oversight of the brutal **Tiananmen Square** military crackdown led to global condemnation.

Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)

BRI Project Examples

- **Uganda: Karuma Hydropower Station**—Uganda borrowed $1.4B from the Exim Bank of China to finance construction.
  - *Pro-BRI:* The hydropower plant, when completed, will provide significant energy infrastructure.
- **Ethiopia: Addis Ababa–Djibouti Railway (2013)**—Exim Bank of China lent $3B to finance construction.
  - *Pro-BRI:* Connects landlocked Ethiopia to the sea via the Port of Djibouti; nearly 95% of Ethiopia's exports are now transported via the railway.
  - *Anti-BRI:* Expected to cost ∼$3B but finished nearly 30% over budget, behind schedule, and lacking necessary additional infrastructure. The state-owned Ethiopian Railway Corporation was expected to repay debts equal to a third of Ethiopia's annual budget. The railway generates ∼$40M in annual revenue but operating costs exceed $70M.
- **Mozambique: Maputo–Katembe Suspension Bridge (2014)**—Exim Bank of China lent ∼$700M; contracted the China Road and Bridge Corporation.
  - *Pro-BRI:* Spans nearly two miles, connecting the capital Maputo to the southern

suburb of Katembe. Expected to expedite urbanisation and facilitate migration of ∼500,000 people.
  - *Anti-BRI:* The cost was estimated at seven times the true construction costs. Plagued by contract mismanagement and working conditions so poor that Mozambican workers went on strike (November 2014).
- **Egypt: New Administrative Capital**—China's State Construction Engineering Corporation plays a key role; Egypt borrowed just over $1B.
  - *Pro-BRI:* Allows Egypt to reduce congestion/overpopulation in Cairo while spurring foreign investment and facilitating useful public infrastructure.
  - *Anti-BRI:* China's contributions largely strengthened the military (primary benefactor). Most construction carried out by Chinese labourers—e.g. nearly 2,000 workers imported from China.

Taiwan, Hong Kong, and Tibet

Hong Kong

- **1997: "The Return" / "The Handover"**—Britain returned all administrative and political control of Hong Kong to China, often seen as the definitive end of Britain's status as a global empire.
- Hong Kong was declared a **Special Administrative Region (SAR):** : retaining a relatively high degree of political, economic, and social autonomy under Chinese control.
- **One Country, Two Systems:** Proposed in the 1980s by Deng Xiaoping. Hong Kong would be "one country" (part of China) but retain "two systems" (its own legal, governmental, financial, and trading structures). The **Basic Law** serves as Hong Kong's de facto constitution. China pledged to maintain this system until 2047 (50 years after the agreement).
- **Early tensions:** In 2003, China sought to mandate educational curriculum praising Chinese-style communism.
- **Extradition crisis:**
  - **2015: Causeway Bay Book Disappearances**—Several journalists critical of Beijing disappeared and were confirmed extradited to mainland China.
  - **2018:** A Hong Kong resident murdered a woman in Taiwan and returned to Hong Kong. No Taiwan–Hong Kong extradition agreement existed. A pro-CCP Hong Kong party pushed for legislation allowing extradition to any Chinese jurisdiction. Mainland China strongly supported the bill.
  - **Carrie Lam** advocated an amendment allowing Hong Kong criminals to be tried in mainland China.
  - **June 2019:** Over 500,000 Hong Kong residents protested, fearing China would use extradition powers to stifle free speech and crack down on pro-democracy advocacy.
  - Dozens of protesters arrested. Lam formally withdrew the amendment, but pro-democracy activists called it "too little, too late." Universal suffrage increasingly became an aim.
  - **October 2019:** Protests turned violent. A protester was shot. Jimmy Sham, a major LGBTQ and political rights activist, was violently attacked and hospitalised. Hong Kong students became central advocates.
  - **Mid-November 2019:** Student protester Chow Tsz-lok died. Police became increasingly violent and abusive.
  - Protests continued into 2020. China passed a restrictive **national security law** giv-

ing mainland authorities broad power to crack down on protests, arbitrarily classify activists/organisations as threats to national security, and treat them as terrorists. The law triggered widespread further protests.

Tibet

- Tibet is a territory in East Asia bordering China (north/east) and India (west), populated primarily by Tibetan people (∼90%). The dominant religion is **Tibetan Buddhism**; the main economic output is subsistence agriculture.
- **1950:** The PRC (recently victorious from the Communist Revolution) invaded and annexed Tibet, a region historically under Chinese control until the 1911 Xinhai Revolution and claimed by both the PRC and ROC.
- **1951: Seventeen Point Agreement**—China coerced the **Dalai Lama** (highest spiritual leader of Tibetan people) into signing, legitimising PRC claims and justifying PLA military expansion, but granting Tibet regional autonomy. The Dalai Lama later repeatedly rejected the agreement, decrying Tibet had been manhandled.
- **1959:** Protests against Chinese rule erupted, fuelled by fears of the Dalai Lama's arrest. Protests were forcibly cracked down upon. The Dalai Lama fled to India, where he was granted asylum and a **Tibetan government-in-exile** was declared.
- **1962:** China and India fought a war in disputed Himalayan regions near Tibet; China won.
- **Humanitarian toll:** Mao's Great Leap Forward devastated Tibetans. The Cultural Revolution destroyed over 6,000 monasteries and the vast majority of culturally significant sites.
- Human rights abuses have been rampant: Tibetan individuals tried in Chinese courts; widespread accusations of physical and cultural genocide.
- Although Tibet is officially an autonomous region of China, the CCP wields significant influence.
- **2008:** Another series of widespread protests erupted. The CCP sent military reinforcements and has maintained a strong presence since.

Taiwan

- **1927–1949: Chinese Civil War**—Between the Republic of China (ROC) and the CCP. After the 1949 Communist Revolution, the CCP expelled the KMT to **Taiwan** (separated from mainland China by the Taiwan Strait).
- The KMT implemented the authoritarian **White Terror:** , cracking down on dissidence and ensuring one-party rule under martial law.
- The US and most of the West recognised the ROC in Taiwan as the legitimate government of China, refusing to recognise the CCP-led PRC.
- **Taiwan Miracle (1950s–1960s):** Dramatic economic growth through export-oriented industrialisation, economic liberalisation, and US economic aid. Taiwan became one of the **Asian Tigers:** (alongside Singapore, Hong Kong, and South Korea).
- **Cross-Strait crises:** Violent conflict broke out during the **First Taiwan Strait Crisis** (1954) and **Second Taiwan Strait Crisis** (1958).
- Western-backed international bodies (including the UN) continued recognising Taiwan as the legitimate government of China, giving the KMT China's seats.
- **1971:** Albania (a close PRC ally) introduced a UN proposal to remove Taiwan's membership and replace it with the PRC. The proposal passed with the required two-thirds majority; the US wanted stronger PRC relations to aid its proxy efforts in Vietnam during

the Cold War. Nixon visited China the following year.

- **Democratisation:**
  - 1975: KMT leader Chiang Kai-shek died. His son, Chiang Ching-kuo, began gradual reforms—crucially, allowing native Taiwanese people into higher government levels (a stark contrast from his father, who prioritised those who fled from China in 1949).
  - 1977: Taiwanese opposition parties secured first election victories.
  - 1979: **Kaohsiung Incident**—protests forcibly shut down, opposition leaders arrested. Drew international attention to political repression; widely considered a pivot point towards democracy.
  - 1987: Martial law suspended.
  - 2000: KMT lost its first presidential election.
- **Secession controversy:**
  - 2004: Re-election of Chen Shui-bian (explicitly pro-independence) worried the CCP. China passed an **anti-secession law** declaring willingness to use non-peaceful means to prevent Taiwan's secession.
  - 2016: President Tsai (Democratic Progressive Party, even more explicitly pro-independence) elected. Cross-Strait tensions intensified when President Trump spoke with Tsai by phone—the first formal US–Taiwan connection since 1979.
  - China has cracked down on countries and companies recognising Taiwanese independence. More recently, China has violated Taiwanese airspace by flying military fighters through Taiwan's territory.
- **Core dispute:** Both the PRC and ROC see themselves as the legitimate government of "China"; the PRC views Taiwan as under its jurisdiction.

Sample Motions

"This House would impose comprehensive sanctions on Russia."

"This House supports the creation of an independent Palestinian state."

"This House believes that NATO should admit Ukraine as a member."

"This House would recognise Taiwan as an independent state."

"This House believes the Belt and Road Initiative does more harm than good."

"This House supports the right of Hong Kong to full democratic self-governance."

"This House would intervene militarily to prevent humanitarian crises."

"This House believes that targeted killings are a legitimate tool of counterterrorism."

"This House opposes nuclear proliferation."

"This House would abolish the EU's unanimity voting requirement for foreign policy."

"This House believes that the international community has failed the Palestinian people."

"This House supports Tibetan independence from China."